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COOK COUNTY COURTS

Big cases, some big changes in 2025

New state's attorney to put her own stamp on the legal system

By Madeline Buckley
Chicago Tribune

Within the Cook County legal system, 2024 in many ways marked a shift in approach that will be noticeable in local courtrooms.

After eight polarizing years, former Cook County State's Attorney Kim Foxx stepped down. Her successor, Eileen O'Neill Burke, a former appellate judge, took office with a different mandate.

O'Neill Burke, who narrowly defeated her Democratic primary opponent, Clayton Harris III, and then Republican Bob Fioretti by a wider margin, came into office in December decrying the consistent scourge of gun violence and announcing a new pretrial detention policy.

It marked a change in tone from Foxx, who was elected in 2016 amid calls for reform after the slaying of 17-year-old Laquan McDonald by Chicago police officer Jason Van Dyke.

O'Neill Burke has begun fleshing out her leadership team, naming former Circuit Court judge and prosecuting veteran Anna Demacopoulos as the first assistant state's attorney. Demacopoulos most recently served on the bench at the Daley Center after being elected in 2008 and previously worked for the state's attorney's office for 23 years, including as a supervisor for the Narcotics Felony Trial Unit.

The new state's attorney appointed as chief of staff Garvin Ambrose, who worked in the administrations of both Foxx and her predecessor Anita Alvarez. Ambrose, who previously was an assistant state's attorney, was chief of staff for Alvarez from 2014 to 2016 and headed the bureau of Administrative Services for Foxx.

O'Neill Burke also named Yvette Loizon, a former partner at Clifford Law Offices, as chief of policy; Jennifer Bagby, a former prosecutor who most recently was an attorney with the city, as chief deputy, and Matt McGrath, who comes from the city's Treasurer's

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NEW ORLEANS TERROR ATTACK

FBI: Driver acted alone

Authorities reverse position in assault they say was inspired by Islamic State group

'Evil act' carried out by Texas man who previewed violence in his Facebook videos



Samantha Petry places flowers at a memorial in New Orleans' French Quarter on Thursday. **GEORGE WALKER IV/AP**

Chicagoans struggle to process deadly New Year's Day rampage in the famed French Quarter, focus on aid

By Sarah Macaraeg and Peter Breen
Chicago Tribune

On New Year's Eve, Notre Dame sophomore and Wheaton native Marco Gonzalez met with five friends at a hotel a few blocks from the Superdome in New Orleans. It was his first time in the city. The crew ventured out to a party spot on Bourbon Street and stayed out until about 1 a.m.

Several hours later, the Wheaton Warrenville South High School graduate said he woke up on a pullout bed at his hotel with "like 30 missed calls" from his mom.

"We all got woken up at like 7 a.m.," Gonzalez said. He and his buddies were getting an onslaught of calls and texts from loved ones who weren't sure whether they were hurt, or worse. "It was surreal, especially considering we were there two hours before."

About 3:15 a.m. Wednesday, a U.S. citizen from Texas sped around a police blockade and raced through a crowd along Bourbon Street, where people had gathered to celebrate the new year. The FBI called the attack, which left 14 people dead, an act of terrorism.

Investigators now believe the driver, Shamsud-Din Jabbar, acted alone and found he posted several

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"It's really tense down here, and we were all kind of feeling that. You're always thinking about it, and there's always something in the back of your mind now that you can't really fully relax."

— Wheaton native Marco Gonzalez, a Notre Dame student in New Orleans for the Sugar Bowl

By Eric Tucker, Jim Mustian, Kevin McGill and Jack Brook
Associated Press

NEW ORLEANS — The Army veteran who drove a pickup into a crowd of New Year's revelers acted alone, the FBI said Thursday, reversing its position from a day earlier that he likely worked with others in the deadly attack that officials said was inspired by the Islamic State group.

The FBI also revealed that the driver, Shamsud-Din Jabbar, 42, a U.S. citizen from Texas, posted five videos on his Facebook account in the hours before the attack in which he proclaimed his support for the militant group and previewed the violence that he would soon unleash in the city's famed French Quarter district.

"This was an act of terrorism. It was premeditated and an evil act," said Christopher Raia, the deputy assistant director of the FBI's counterterrorism division, calling Jabbar "100% inspired" by Islamic State.

The attack killed 14 revelers, along with Jabbar, who was fatally shot in a firefight with police after steering his speeding truck around a barricade and plowing into the crowd.

It was the deadliest IS-inspired assault on U.S. soil in years, laying bare what federal officials have warned is a resurgent international terrorism threat and coming as the FBI and other agencies brace for dramatic leadership upheaval — and likely policy

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Bald eagles, now officially national bird, not uncommon in city



A bald eagle soars above the Micro Center store at the Diversey Parkway turning basin on the North Branch of the Chicago River on Monday. **TESS CROWLEY/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

By Peter Breen
Chicago Tribune

Many dream of waking up on Christmas to a mound of presents stacked around a tree. Others simply wish to glimpse a few snowflakes when looking out the window.

And then there's Alexandra Greenberg, who walked onto her back balcony on the holiday and saw two adult bald eagles.

"They were fishing," said Greenberg, 34, who lives with her husband along the North Branch of the Chicago River in the Lathrop Homes area. "We saw one first and then we saw the second. It was just magnificent."

The bald eagle, a symbol of the power and the strength of the United States for more than 240

years, officially became the country's national bird on Christmas Eve. It once avoided Chicago like the plague.

But a nest high in a tree beside the Little Calumet River in Chicago in 2004 was the first bald eagle nest spotted in the Chicago area for more than a century, according to the U.S. Forest Service.

And by the end of 2021, 35 bald eagle nests had been spotted in the Chicago area, according to the Forest Service. On Tuesday morning on eBird — Cornell University's popular bird-watching smartphone app — almost 60 bald eagle sightings in the past week had been reported within a circle centered at the Willis Tower with a 30-mile radius.

"I wouldn't say it's a common bird, but it's definitely not uncommon," said Matt Igleski, executive director of the Chicago Bird Alliance. "If you're in the right habitat in the city, you can basically expect to see them or possibly run into them at any time."

In the 1780s, when the bald eagle became a symbol of the United States, "anecdotal accounts" stated the country might have had 100,000 nesting eagles, according to the U.S. Fish and Wildlife Service.

The species' population declined in the middle of the 19th century due to a loss of nesting habitat and they were often shot, according to the Fish and Wildlife Service. Even though the large raptors mostly eat fish and carrion, they were killed because they were

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TODAY'S WEATHER



High 23 Low 11

Complete Chicagoland forecast on Page 12

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